

THE SOM SURVEY AND THE CITIZEN PANEL

OPEN DATA, COLLABORATION AND NOT-SO-OPEN DATA?

The SOM Institute

An independent research organisation at the University of Gothenburg. Since 1986, we have combined a close relation to survey research with a strong presence in the public debate.



**The Swedish
Citizen Panel**

Brief history

- Started in 1986 as a collaborative survey project between researchers in political science and media studies
- Became a centre at the Faculty of Social Sciences in 2010
- Joined together with the Swedish Citizen Panel in 2014
- Became a national research infrastructure supported by the Swedish Science Council (VR) in 2018

The purpose of the SOM Institute

- Serve as an efficient, high-quality research infrastructure for survey-based data collections in Sweden
- Conduct long-term research and analysis on the Swedish societal development
- Actively communicate results outside of the university
- Conduct research collaborations outside of academia with public agencies
- Conduct methodological research and development on survey data collections

Organisation and staff

In total, 17 employees:

- Research Director: Annika Bergström
- 5 Researchers (political science, media, psychology/economics, survey methodology)
- 2 Survey managers and 7 Assistant survey managers
- 1 Communications officer, 1 Administrator



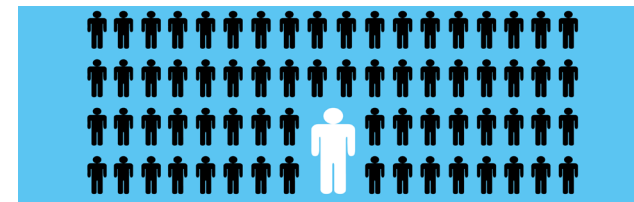
Two main facilities for data collections

The annual SOM surveys



- Large cross-sectional, representative samples of the Swedish population (mainly paper surveys)

The Swedish Citizen Panel



- Online access panel (strictly web surveys)

Our different types of open/available data

- (Collaboration within our surveys and panels)
- Secondary datasets for researchers and students
 - SOM-surveys and the CORE-panel
- All of our publications freely available online
- Aggregated data available directly and freely online:
 - <https://som-institutet.se/dataanalys>
- Completely open and transparent methodology:
 - <https://www.gu.se/som-institutet/som-undersokningarna/metod>
 - <https://www.gu.se/som-institutet/medborgarpanelen/for-dig-som-forskar>
 - <https://www.gu.se/som-institutet/medborgarpanelen/for-dig-som-forskar/panelvagor-och-tekniska-rapporter>

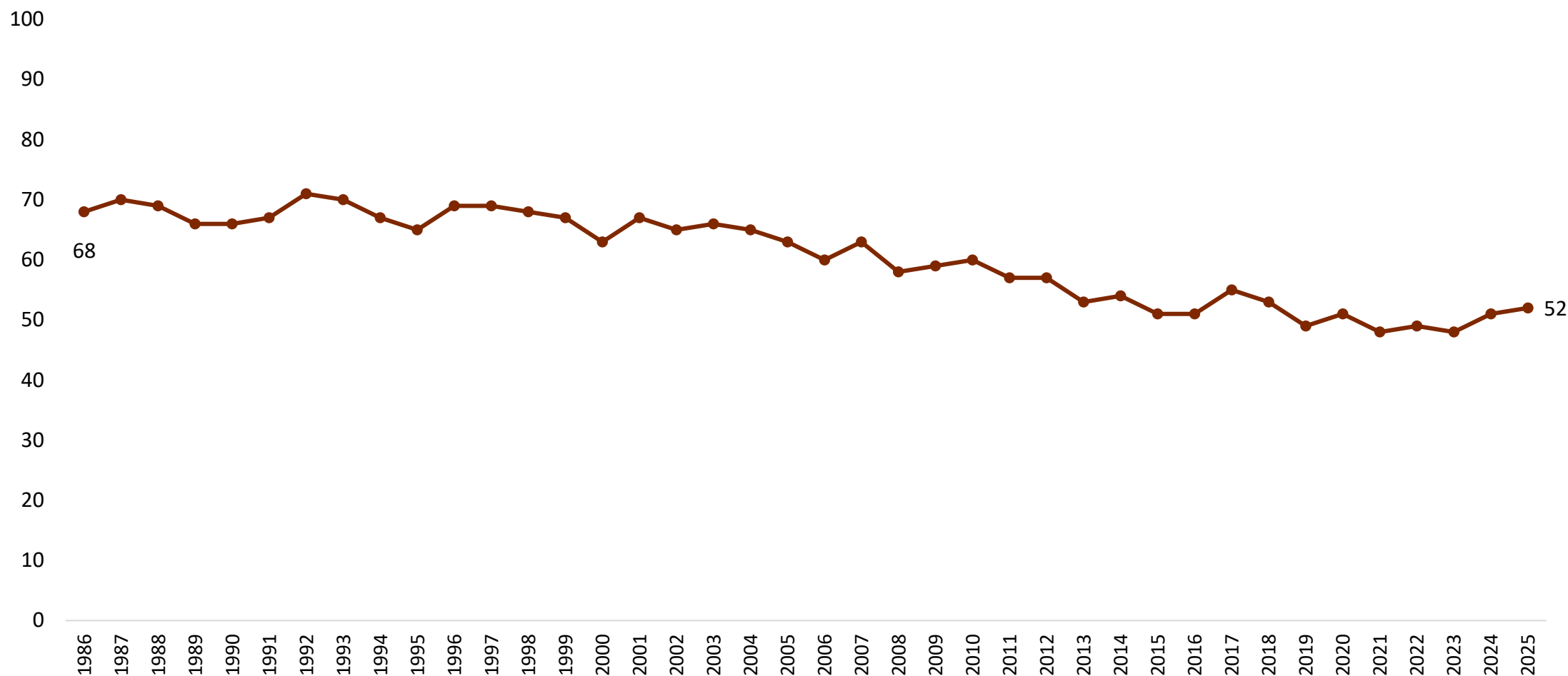
The SOM-surveys

How the SOM-surveys are conducted

- Yearly national (n=26 250), regional (n=6 000) and local surveys (n=9 000)
- A paper questionnaire is delivered to the respondent with an option to respond online
- The questionnaires are between 12-16 pages
- Five postal reminders, two text messages and reminders via digital mailbox are sent out during the field period (which is 100 days)
- Respondents receive a lottery ticket after having sent in their survey
- After the field period is ended all direct identifiers/keys are destroyed, so that individuals can't be identified

Response rate over time in the national SOM survey

1986–2025 (percent)

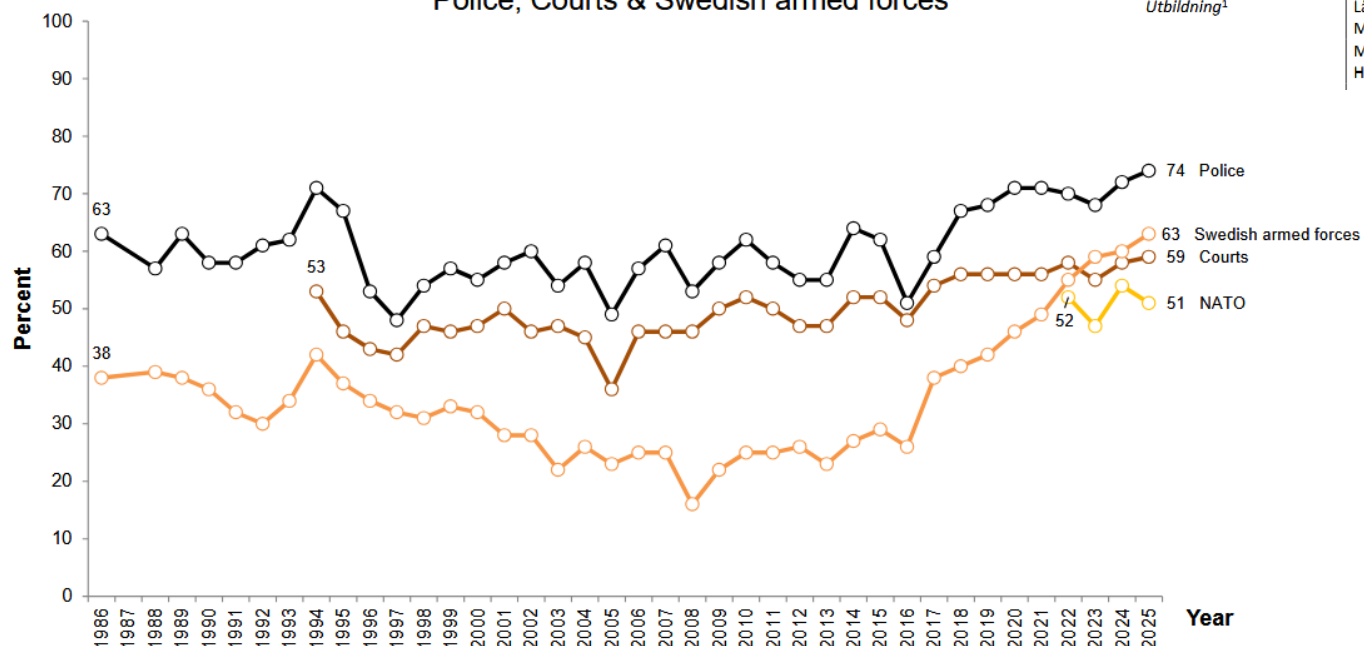


Results from the SOM-surveys

- Often in the form of time-series
- However also many group comparisons

CONFIDENCE IN INSTITUTIONS

Police, Courts & Swedish armed forces



Comment: Five response alternatives to the question asked: "Very much; Fairly much; Neither much nor little; Fairly little; Very little". The lines show the percentage of respondents indicating very or fairly much confidence. The percentages are based on the respondents answering each individual item.

Question: "How much confidence do you have in the way the following institutions/groups do their job?"

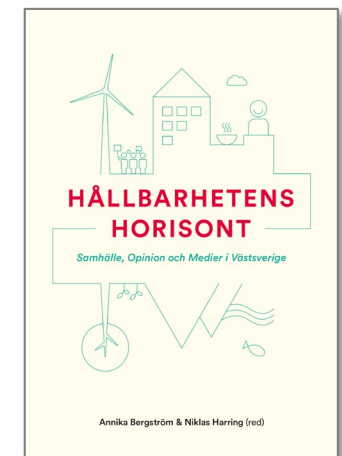
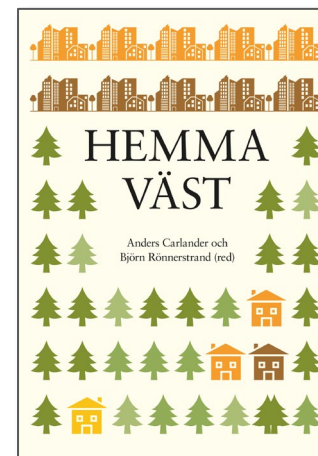
Source: The National SOM survey 1986–2025

Tabell 2 Använt AI-chatbot privat, 2025 (procent)

		Ingen gång	Någon gång de senaste 12 mån	Någon gång i halvåret	Någon gång i månaden	Någon gång i veckan	Flera gånger i veckan	Dagligen	Summa procent	Antal svarande
<i>Samtliga</i>		42	6	5	13	13	13	8	100	1 704
<i>Kön</i>	Kvinna	44	6	5	13	11	13	8	100	866
	Man	41	6	4	13	14	14	8	100	834
<i>Ålder</i>	16–29 år	12	6	6	12	18	28	18	100	210
	30–49 år	21	10	6	20	15	17	11	100	470
	50–64 år	38	6	6	15	18	11	6	100	477
	65+ år	78	3	1	5	4	6	3	100	547
<i>Utbildning¹</i>	Låg	72	5	2	7	4	5	5	100	195
	Medellåg	48	6	5	11	11	12	7	100	478
	Medelhög	42	5	5	16	12	14	6	100	382
	Hög	29	7	5	14	17	17	11	100	620

(Our own) annual output – the SOM surveys

- Datasets: 3–5
- Book series (anthologies): 1–3 each year
- General and/or themed reports : 40+ each year
- Notes on survey methodology 2–3 each
- Presentations and seminars



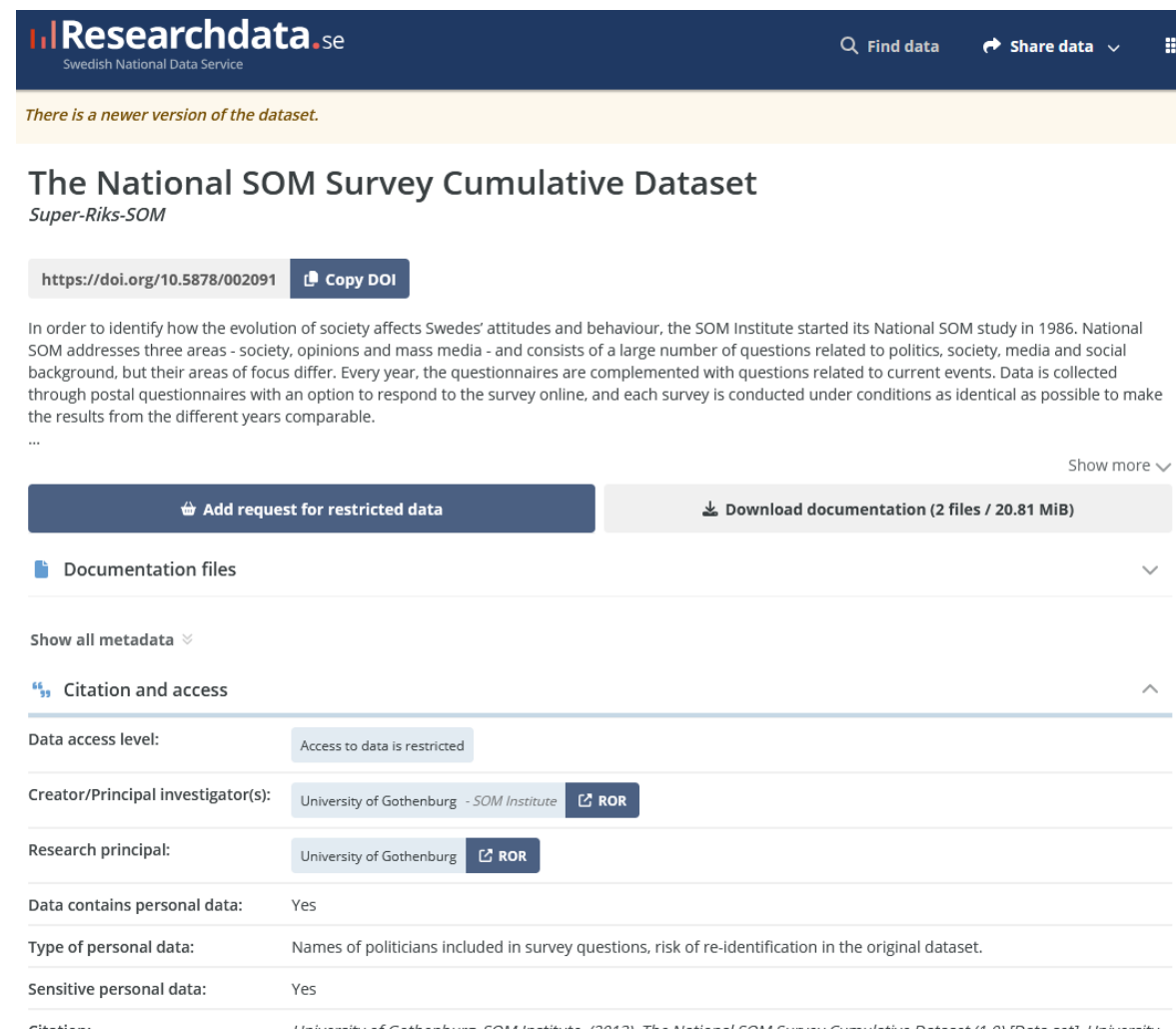
Making data available

From the SOM survey each year:

- 3-4 datasets from the annual surveys
- 3 cumulative datasets 1986-

- Available for any researcher
- Also available for students

- Free to request via Researchdata.se



Researchdata.se
Swedish National Data Service

Find data Share data

There is a newer version of the dataset.

The National SOM Survey Cumulative Dataset

Super-Riks-SOM

<https://doi.org/10.5878/002091> [Copy DOI](#)

In order to identify how the evolution of society affects Swedes' attitudes and behaviour, the SOM Institute started its National SOM study in 1986. National SOM addresses three areas - society, opinions and mass media - and consists of a large number of questions related to politics, society, media and social background, but their areas of focus differ. Every year, the questionnaires are complemented with questions related to current events. Data is collected through postal questionnaires with an option to respond to the survey online, and each survey is conducted under conditions as identical as possible to make the results from the different years comparable.

...

[Add request for restricted data](#) [Download documentation \(2 files / 20.81 MiB\)](#)

Documentation files

Show all metadata

Citation and access

Data access level: Access to data is restricted

Creator/Principal investigator(s): University of Gothenburg - SOM Institute [ROR](#)

Research principal: University of Gothenburg [ROR](#)

Data contains personal data: Yes

Type of personal data: Names of politicians included in survey questions, risk of re-identification in the original dataset.

Sensitive personal data: Yes

Citation: University of Gothenburg, SOM Institute. (2022). The National SOM Survey Cumulative Dataset (Super-Riks-SOM). University of Gothenburg.

What data is not made available?

- While all data from the SOM surveys eventually become freely available to researchers and students there are some restrictions.
- Data we collect during e.g. the autumn/winter of 2025 first becomes available in the spring of 2027, giving our collaborating partners a chance to do their own research.
- Even as data is made available, for the first five years data is "reduced". Open-ended questions are removed, some geographical variables (such as municipality) and other variables which increase the risk of backwards-identification are also removed or aggregated.
- After five years a more complete dataset is added to Researchdata.

Collaboration within the SOM surveys

- Researchers can collaborate with SOM to include their own questions in the survey
- SOM assists with question wording, as well as questions of scales and other methodological aspects
- This type of collaboration is associated with a cost
- SOM does however not strive to make any profit, the fee is simply based on the space questions take in our survey and our costs of conducting the survey
- See more information here:
 - <https://www.gu.se/en/som-institute/collaboration/collect-data-in-the-som-surveys>

Annual output from others using SOM data

- Data requested by 150 students for use in student papers
- Data requested by on average 30 Ph.D. students per year
- Approximately 40 peer reviewed journal articles per year
- Several 100 news articles referencing SOM per year

The Swedish Citizen Panel

The Swedish Citizen Panel

- Online Access Panel (no other survey modes offered)
- Academically administered
- Exclusively used for research:
 - Longitudinal studies
 - Survey-embedded experiments (including conjoint)
 - Cross-sectional studies
 - Recruitment to qualitative studies

The Swedish Citizen Panel

- Approximately 70 000 participants aged 16+ living in Sweden
- Self-recruited and probability-recruited participants:
 - Self-recruited: 70%
 - Probability-recruited: 30%
- No economic incentives are offered to participants
- The large number of participants enable targeted sampling across socio-demographic groups, professions, opinions and habits
 - Tailored solutions

Waves

- We conduct four large omnibus survey waves each year: in February, June, September, and December
- Each wave includes several different studies, ranging from survey experiments to cross-sectional studies
- In addition to these omnibus waves, separate projects and questionnaires can also be conducted between waves upon request.
- Participation rate around 60 percent

Based on collaboration with other research groups

- Researchers may apply to collaborate for a user fee
 - Cost is estimated based on the type of sample, the length of the questionnaire, and the number of requested completed responses
- Feedback on the questionnaire is provided to researchers, including suggested revisions
- We offer support with ethical review and data management plans
 - Technical reports are provided after each data collection
- Approximate timeline: About 3 months from application to completed data collection
- Approval from the Swedish Ethical Review Authority is required when collecting sensitive personal data



More information about collaboration
with the Swedish Citizen Panel

Technical reports for each data collection

2026

Medborgarpanelen våg 61



Technical report wave 61 (pdf)

Fältperiod: 2026-02-18 - 2026-03-11

Urvalsstorlek: 71 249

Svarsfrekvens (AAPOR Participation Rate): 61%

↓ pdf, 428.84 KB

2025

Medborgarpanelen våg 60



Technical report wave 60 (pdf)

Fältperiod: 2025-12-09 - 2026-01-09

Urvalsstorlek: 9 620

Svarsfrekvens (AAPOR Participation Rate): 60%

↓ pdf, 377.84 KB

Medborgarpanelen våg 59



Technical report wave 59 (pdf)

Fältperiod: 2025-09-24 - 2025-10-16

Urvalsstorlek: 22 036

Svarsfrekvens (AAPOR Participation Rate): 65%

↓ pdf, 416.15 KB



<https://www.gu.se/som-institutet/medborgarpanelen/for-dig-som-forskar/panelvagor-och-tekniska-rapporter>

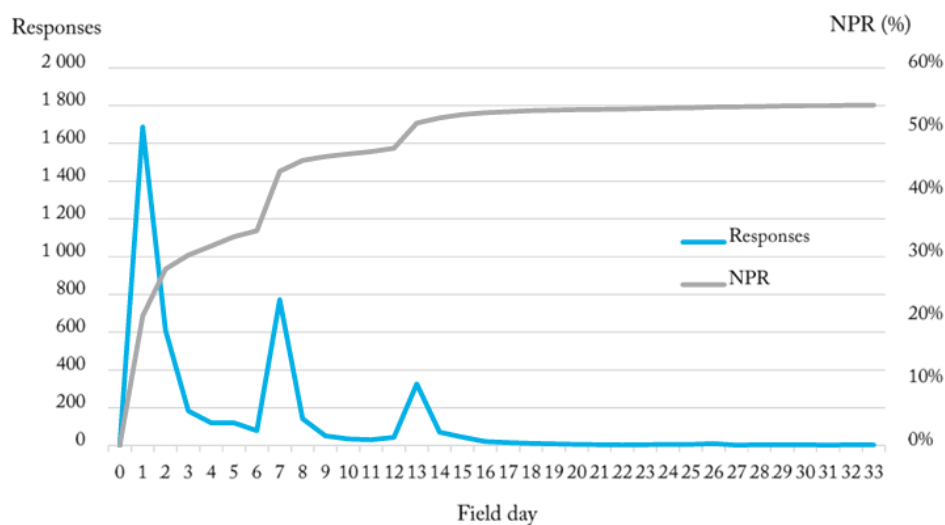
Technical report example

Fieldwork

Table 1: Field information

Name	Citizen Panel 56 (MP56)
No. of field days	33
Soft launch	Day 1: Thursday December 5th, 14:15, 2025
Main launch	Day 1: Thursday December 5th, 15:50, 2025
Reminder 1	Day 7: Wednesday December 11th, 08:00, 2025
Reminder 2	Day 13: Tuesday December 17th, 12:00, 2025
Field end	Day 33: Tuesday January 7th, 11:00, 2025

Figure 1: Number of responses / cumulative net participation rate (%) by field day



Study 5: Order and question effects in climate related issues

Table 11: Study 5, Order and question effects in climate related issues

Sample	
Source	Probability
Pre-stratification variables or other selection criteria	Sex*Age*Education
Age frame	18-85
Sample disposition	
Total panelists invited ($I+P+R+NC+O$)	8 000
Completed study; more than 80% answered questions (I)	4 139
Partial study; 50%-80% answered questions (P)	107
Break-offs; fewer than 50% answered questions (R)	85
Refusals (R)	3 465
E-mail bounce backs or failed deliveries (NC)	204
Other (O)	0
Participation rate	
Participation rate (PR)	52%
Net participation rate (NPR)	53%
Devices among completes	
Computer device	34%
Mobile device	61%
Tablet device	5%

Table 12: Details on Study 5, Order and question effects in climate related issues

	Mean	Median	Std. Dev.	N.
Number of received/applicable items	16.03	17.00	1.59	4 331
Number of item responses	15.54	15.00	2.63	4 331
Item response rate	0.97	1.00	0.13	4 331
Minutes to answer, excluding outliers	2.22	2.05	0.94	3 948
Seconds per item, excluding outliers	8.01	7.31	3.64	3 939
Minutes to answer, including outliers	2.91	2.13	7.01	4 318
Seconds per item, including outliers	10.39	7.55	25.06	4 309
Seconds per item, speeders	2.62	2.73	0.47	52
Seconds per item, sleepers	41.12	23.93	85.70	318

The CORE panel

- In addition to collaborating research projects, we also have our own longitudinal panel
- About 4 000 panelists
- Get identical questionnaires once or twice per year
 - The surveys include a set of societally relevant questions related to: subjective health, media use, political ideology and attitudes, trust in public institutions, social trust, and perceptions of Sweden's economy
- The panel has been active since 2010 (35 waves)
- Available for researchers for a fee
 - Ethical approval from the Swedish Ethical Review Authority is required

Data availability

- Data from the Swedish Citizen Panel is only shared with collaborating researchers
- The CORE panel is available to researchers for a fee
- In general, data are not publicly accessible due to legal restrictions related to the panel structure
- We provide legal guidelines for researchers working with our data

Open and transparent research

All methodology and publications freely available online

- Our ambition is that everything we do is to be freely and publicly available online.
- Everything we do in terms of methodology, field plan, outline of our surveys and reminders, data processing and so on is available on our website
 - <https://www.gu.se/som-institutet/som-undersokningarna/metod>
 - <https://www.gu.se/som-institutet/som-undersokningarna/frageformular-och-kodbocker>
- All of our publications, books, methodological notes, report and more also available for free:
 - <https://www.gu.se/som-institutet/resultat-och-publikationer>
 - <https://som-institutet.se/publikationssok>
 - <https://www.gu.se/som-institutet/resultat-och-publikationer/metodforskning>

Thank you for your attention!

Questions?

Contact: marcus.weissenbilder@som.gu.se